

Heroes, heartbreak and the space between

The unforgettable performances and **moments that shaped** football's biggest stage.

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REUTERS

Vozinha: The new fan favourite

Cape Verde was the only team to deny eventual champion Spain a goal throughout the tournament. The African nation, with a population of just half a million, faced the pre-tournament favourite in its very first group-stage game. As expected, Spain dominated proceedings but could not breach the goal guarded by its 40-year-old goalkeeper, Josimar Dias, better known as Vozinha.

La Furia Roja attempted 27 shots, but none proved venomous enough to beat Vozinha,

who also became the second-oldest player to start a FIFA World Cup match. He made seven saves to ensure his team came away with a point.

Vozinha's World Cup exploits earned him more than 20 million Instagram followers as Cape Verde became the smallest nation by population to reach the knockout stage. The admiration continued even after the team's Round of 32 exit, with a newly discovered sea slug species named after the goalkeeper: *Aldisa vozinhai*.



REUTERS

Lionel Messi notches up his first World Cup hat-trick

Argentina arrived at this World Cup carrying the burden of being the defending champion, while also relying on a 39-year-old talisman who now plies his trade away from the limelight of European football, in Major League Soccer.

Lionel Messi and his team had relatively modest opponents in their group, but the fear of an early elimination has gripped the defending champion before. Against this backdrop, Messi ensured La Albiceleste shook off any jitters by producing a hat-trick against Algeria and leading his side to a 3-0 victory.

It was his first World Cup hat-trick, arriving in his sixth World Cup campaign, and it took his tally to 16 goals, drawing level with Germany's Miroslav Klose for the all-time record. Messi eventually finished with eight goals in the tournament, taking his overall haul to 20 in what was, most probably, his final World Cup.